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Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1966-1974

Coverage Date: 1966-1974

Place Coverage

Kade area, Central Kalahari Game Reserve, Botswana

Section Title(S): Political Organization

Although children contribute hardly at all to the economic life of the San, they are nonetheless recognized as full-status individuals and are treated with great indulgence. They play freely, beg food, and generally are permitted to have their way. Older children and adults must take care to ensure the safety of the youngsters. There is no division into age grades with clearly defined social roles; it goes no farther than defining the moral relationship between individuals based on their relative ages.

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In “primitive” societies like the San’s, one does not have sudden discontinuities as in civilized societies; the same value system and ethics are maintained, so that old people do not get left behind on the far side of a generation gap. In this society it is precisely the experiences of life that lead to the accumulation of knowledge, and they may become the source of authority. Hence old people, especially the very old, are respected and may exercise leadership through their words and actions.

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A great bowman who is young and sturdy may become respected as a famous hunter, and his opinion in hunting matters will carry much weight. There are also people skilled at incantations to cure illnesses, or at making tools, or at storytelling, and while they do not become specialists, they do take a leading position in activities in their sphere of ability and receive prestige.

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There are, then, experts who take a leading role in various phases of daily life, and people who can bring the group together, solve problems, and settle disputes in certain situations. These people play an important part in the workings of the society; they become leaders, however, only in those particular situations or contexts, and in no way does anyone function as a "chief" who could regulate the whole of society.

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The words of these individuals definitely carry weight in the areas of their prestige, but only as nonbinding suggestions, and there is no compulsion to follow these suggestions. The major decisions in the social life of the San are taken at the "conferences," in which anyone living in the camp may participate. The "conferences" are not at all formal and do not take place in a special spot. They grow out of the normal everyday chat sessions that occur around the fires in front of the huts, or in the shade of a tree at midday; the participants may be making tools or doing other handiwork, or just lying around. While trading rumors and jokes, chatting about the doings at other camps, the movement of  109 game, and hunting conditions, they will discuss their plans for hunting and decide the date and destination of their next move. Since the San decry stealing and prefer to settle disputes peaceably, theft and violence are almost unknown. If an altercation occurs or interpersonal frictions arise, a more serious social crisis is averted by geographical separation of the parties involved through group realignment. The most serious quarrels are caused by adultery, but disagreements also arise over the distribution of food. Real trouble over food distribution arises less often over the amount received than over differences of opinion as to who should be the primary distributors and who the secondary. For example, A might receive some meat from C and D and yet complain that it really should have come from B. Such matters will be discussed and any necessary sanctions imposed verbally.

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